

Google Pixel Buds 2a

Made for Pixel users, pleasant for everyone else

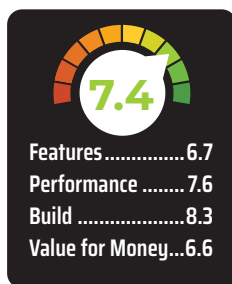
The Google Pixel lineup, be it smartphones or wearables, is known for a simple and clean experience. It has been a minute since we got the Pixel Buds 2a, but they follow the same thinking, designed to fade into the background while remaining proactively useful. They sat in my rotation as daily-use earbuds, and after extensive use, it became clear what they do well and where they fall short. At Rs 12,999, they sit in a crowded and unforgiving segment. This is where spec-heavy options like OnePlus Buds Pro 3 and Nothing Ear dominate conversations, and where buyers expect wireless charging, high-resolution codecs, and big battery numbers. Google, however, takes a different route: less hardware flexing and more focus on comfort, software, and ecosystem polish.

CLEAN DESIGN

The Pixel Buds 2a case is plain white, which inevitably reminds you of AirPods, but the shape is more oblong and pebble-like rather than boxy. It is one of the easiest to carry around. It is compact, light, and slips into a jeans pocket without creating a bulge. There is no Google or Pixel logo anywhere on the outside, giving the case a clean aesthetic.

The buds have a G logo, and the right orientation of that G helps in rightly placing them in the case. Another small usability issue is identifying left and right earbuds. They look identical at a glance. Thankfully, the L and R markings are placed on the side that faces your ear, which helps once you get used to checking before putting them on.

While the default ear tips felt slightly loose for me, switching to a smaller ear



tip improved the fit. The earbuds themselves are very light. Once inserted, you have to twist them anticlockwise slightly to lock them in place.

Touch controls are very responsive, and you don't have to put much pressure to trigger the touch functions. Overall, they don't cause fatigue over long hours.

The Pixel Buds 2a are rated IP54 for dust and water resistance, but the case is only IPX4 rated. You need to be careful during monsoons, as that '4' means they can withstand splash only.

BASICS FOR ANDROID

Pairing the Buds 2a with a Pixel phone does make a qualitative difference. Advanced spatial audio, Super Wideband voice, and deeper assistant integration are all Pixel-exclusive. This creates a tiered experience. But these,

I feel, are not super important features and pairing the earbuds with a non-Pixel phone like my Galaxy S23 and OnePlus 13 worked just fine.

You get only AAC and SBC codecs and no advanced codecs like LDAC, LHDC, etc, which its competitors like Nothing Ear (2024), JBL Live Beam 3, Sennheiser Accentum, EarFun Air Pro 4, and even budget options like Noise Master Buds offer.

Hands-free digital assistant support works through Google's wake-word detection. You can trigger Gemini or Google Assistant without touching the buds. In practice, this works reliably and feels faster than many third-party implementations. It can be useful for navigation, quick queries, and reminders while walking, but I don't feel comfortable using this feature on Indian roads or indoors.

Another nifty ecosystem feature is Audio Switch. The device supports multipoint, but Audio Switch is different, as it lets you automatically move audio between signed-in devices like your Pixel phone, Chromebook, or Android tablet. Multipoint, on the other hand, allows the Buds 2a to stay connected to two devices at once, for example, a phone and my MacBook Air.

Wear detection works flawlessly. Music pauses instantly when you remove an earbud and resumes reliably when you put it back in.

The Pixel Buds app is simple. Too simple, some might feel. There are fewer toggles and customisation options compared to Samsung or Nothing. For instance, there are single tap, double tap, and triple tap gestures, along with press-and-hold. The downside is that these gestures are pre-configured. You cannot freely map everything the way you can with Nothing or Samsung earbuds. That said, the basics are covered.

WARM, FRIENDLY SOUND

The Pixel Buds 2a deliver a warm, rounded bass rather than a sharp slam. On tracks like Kehlani's 'Folded', the